Forum:	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO)
Issue:	Mitigating anthropogenic degradation of cultural heritage sites
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Introduction

Human activity is now the single largest cause of damage to the world's cultural heritage. In 2026 alone, the World Heritage Committee placed six more sites on the List of World Heritage in Danger, bringing the total to 58. Almost every one of them is threatened by something people do: war, looting, uncontrolled development, mining, poaching, mass tourism or the consequences of climate change.

The word *anthropogenic* simply means "caused by humans". It covers a wide spectrum. At one end is deliberate destruction: the Taliban dynamiting the Bamiyan Buddhas in 2001, ISIS blowing up the temples of Palmyra in 2015, or armed groups looting the Sudan National Museum in 2023–2025 until only one major statue remained. At the other end is slow, unintentional erosion: millions of footsteps wearing down ancient marble, cruise ships pushing wakes into Venice's foundations, a highway cutting through a historic landscape, or air pollution blackening a cathedral. Between the two lie neglect, poor restoration, illegal excavation and the climate crisis, which is itself a human-made phenomenon.

The scale is large and growing. As of March 2026, UNESCO had independently verified damage to 523 cultural sites in Ukraine, while the Ukrainian government counts more than 2,000. UNESCO has verified damage to 164 sites in the Gaza Strip since October 2023. In Lebanon, strikes near the ancient city of Tyre led the Committee to place it on the Danger List in July 2026. Meanwhile, climate change is now the leading threat to 43% of natural World Heritage sites according to the IUCN, and cities from Venice to Athens have introduced entry fees and visitor caps to stop overtourism from damaging their monuments.

The international community already has a strong legal framework, built around the 1954 Hague Convention, the 1970 UNESCO Convention against illicit trafficking, and the 1972 World Heritage Convention. The problem is implementation. Many States lack the money, trained staff and data to protect their sites. Enforcement against those who destroy heritage in war is rare; the International Criminal Court has convicted only one person, Ahmad Al Faqi Al Mahdi, solely for the destruction of cultural heritage. Economic pressure to develop land and attract tourists often outweighs conservation. And the main specialised agency, UNESCO, faces budget pressure as the United States prepares to leave the organisation on 31 December 2026.

Key Terms and Definitions

Cultural Heritage

The legacy of physical artefacts and intangible attributes inherited from past generations and preserved for future ones. It includes *tangible* heritage (monuments, buildings, archaeological sites, artworks, manuscripts) and *intangible* heritage (traditions, languages, rituals, crafts). This topic focuses on tangible heritage sites, but delegates should remember that destroying a site often destroys the living practices connected to it.

Cultural Heritage Site

A place of recognised historical, archaeological, architectural, artistic or spiritual significance. It may be a single monument, an archaeological area, a historic city centre, a sacred landscape or a museum. A site does not need to be on any international list to count as heritage.

Anthropogenic Degradation

Damage, deterioration or destruction caused directly or indirectly by human activity. It contrasts with purely natural processes such as earthquakes or ordinary weathering. It includes intentional acts (vandalism, iconoclasm, attacks in war, looting) and unintentional ones (overtourism, pollution, development pressure, poor restoration, and human-driven climate change).

World Heritage Site (World Heritage Property)

A site inscribed on UNESCO's World Heritage List under the 1972 World Heritage Convention because it holds Outstanding Universal Value. After the 2026 session in Busan, the List contains 1,273 properties in 173 countries: 991 cultural, 240 natural and 42 mixed.

Outstanding Universal Value (OUV)

Cultural or natural significance so exceptional that it transcends national boundaries and matters to all humanity. A site must meet at least one of ten criteria, plus conditions of integrity and authenticity, to be inscribed. Loss of OUV can lead to a site being removed from the List.

List of World Heritage in Danger (Danger List)

A list kept under Article 11(4) of the 1972 Convention for properties facing serious and specific threats. Inscription is meant to unlock international attention and emergency assistance, though some governments see it as a stigma. As of July 2026 it holds 58 properties.

Delisting

The removal of a property from the World Heritage List because it has lost the qualities for which it was inscribed. Only a few sites have ever been delisted, including Dresden Elbe Valley (Germany, 2009) after a bridge was built through it and Liverpool Maritime Mercantile City (United Kingdom, 2021) after waterfront development.

Cultural Property

The legal term used in the 1954 Hague Convention and the 1970 UNESCO Convention for movable and immovable objects of great importance to the cultural heritage of a people. It covers monuments, archaeological sites, works of art, manuscripts, museums, libraries and archives.

Enhanced Protection

The highest level of immunity for cultural property in armed conflict, created by the Second Protocol (1999) to the Hague Convention. Property under enhanced protection may never be made a military objective, and attacking it is a serious violation that States must prosecute. In 2024–2026 Lebanon secured enhanced protection for 73 cultural properties, including Baalbek and Tyre.

Illicit Trafficking of Cultural Property

The illegal excavation, theft, export, import or sale of cultural objects. Looted antiquities are often used to finance armed groups and organised crime, and online marketplaces have made them easier to sell.

Overtourism

A situation in which the number of visitors to a destination exceeds its carrying capacity, damaging the site, the environment and the quality of life of residents. Examples include Venice, the Acropolis of Athens, Machu Picchu and Angkor.

Carrying Capacity

The maximum number of people a site can receive at one time or per day without unacceptable damage to its physical fabric, its setting or its visitors' experience.

Heritage Impact Assessment (HIA)

A study carried out before a development project (such as a road, dam, mine or high-rise building) to evaluate how it could affect a heritage site's values, and how harm can be avoided or reduced. UNESCO and ICOMOS published updated guidance in 2022.

Buffer Zone

An area surrounding a heritage site in which development is restricted to protect the site and its setting.

Cultural Rights

Human rights that protect everyone's ability to take part in cultural life, including to access and enjoy cultural heritage (Article 27 UDHR; Article 15 ICESCR). The UN Special Rapporteur in the field of cultural rights has argued that intentional destruction of cultural heritage is a violation of human rights.

Restitution

The return of cultural property to its country or community of origin after it was stolen, illegally exported or taken in circumstances such as colonial rule.

Background Information

Historical Context

The destruction of heritage is as old as war itself. Conquerors razed Carthage in 146 BC, sacked Rome in 410 and 455 AD, and burned libraries from Alexandria to Baghdad. Iconoclasm, the deliberate destruction of religious images, swept Byzantium in the 8th century and Europe during the Reformation. For most of history, plunder was considered a legitimate reward of victory.

This began to change in the 19th century. The Lieber Code (1863), written for Union forces in the American Civil War, required the protection of libraries, museums and works of art. The Hague Conventions of 1899 and 1907 prohibited the seizure and destruction of historic monuments. Yet the two World Wars showed how weak these rules were. The bombing of cities such as Dresden, Warsaw and Coventry, and the systematic Nazi looting of art across Europe, destroyed heritage on an unprecedented scale.

After 1945, the newly founded UNESCO made heritage protection one of its core missions. The 1954 Hague Convention was the first treaty dedicated solely to protecting cultural property in war. In the 1960s, the construction of the Aswan High Dam in Egypt threatened to flood the temples of Abu Simbel and Philae. UNESCO launched an international campaign that raised about USD 80 million from some 50 countries to move the temples to higher ground. The campaign proved that heritage could be treated as a shared responsibility of humanity, and it led directly to the 1972 World Heritage Convention.

Since then, the threats have diversified. The late 20th century added mass tourism, rapid urbanisation and industrial pollution. The 21st century added the deliberate, publicised destruction of heritage by extremist groups, industrial-scale looting financed through online markets, and the accelerating effects of climate change.

Why Cultural Heritage Matters

Identity and memory

Heritage sites anchor a community's sense of who it is. This is precisely why aggressors target them: destroying a people's mosques, churches, libraries or monuments is a way to erase their presence and claim over a territory.

Human rights

Access to and enjoyment of cultural heritage is part of the right to take part in cultural life. Its destruction often goes hand in hand with persecution and, in the worst cases, genocide.

Economy and livelihoods

Heritage tourism supports millions of jobs, especially in developing countries. Damaged or unsafe sites mean lost income for whole regions.

Education and knowledge

Archaeological sites and archives are irreplaceable sources of knowledge. Once a layer of an archaeological site is looted or bulldozed, the information it held is lost forever.

Peace and reconciliation

Rebuilding shared heritage after conflict, as with the Old Bridge of Mostar (rebuilt 2004) or the Al-Nouri Mosque in Mosul, can help communities heal.

The Main Drivers of Anthropogenic Degradation

1. Armed Conflict and Deliberate Destruction

Deliberate destruction of heritage in war is often called *cultural cleansing*: an attempt to wipe out a group's history alongside the group itself. The shelling of Dubrovnik (1991) and the destruction of the Old Bridge of Mostar (1993) during the wars in the former Yugoslavia were early modern examples. In March 2001, the Taliban dynamited the 6th-century Buddhas of Bamiyan in Afghanistan. In 2012, armed groups in northern Mali destroyed mausoleums in Timbuktu. Between 2014 and 2017, ISIS destroyed or damaged the temples of Bel and Baalshamin in Palmyra, the ancient cities of Nimrud and Hatra, and the Al-Nouri Mosque in Mosul.

Today's conflicts continue the pattern, though most damage now comes from heavy bombardment in populated areas rather than ideological demolition:

- **Ukraine.** As of March 2026, UNESCO had verified damage to 523 cultural sites since February 2022. The Ukrainian Ministry of Culture reported 2,161 damaged heritage sites by the end of September 2026. World Heritage properties have also been hit, including the Kyiv-Pechersk Lavra in January 2026 and the historic centre of Lviv in March 2026. UNESCO estimated cultural damage at about USD 3.5 billion two years into the war.
- **Gaza.** As of March 2026, UNESCO had verified damage to 164 sites since October 2023, including religious sites, historic buildings, museums and archaeological sites. Most of Gaza City's historic core has been damaged or destroyed.
- **Lebanon.** Repeated strikes near Baalbek and Tyre led UNESCO to grant enhanced protection to 34 Lebanese properties in 2024 and 39 more in 2026. In July 2026 Tyre was added to the Danger List.
- **Sudan.** Since April 2023 the war between the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces has led to the looting of the Sudan National Museum in Khartoum, where only one large statue survived. Museums in Omdurman, Nyala and El Fasher were also looted or damaged.

2. Looting and Illicit Trafficking

Looting is often the hidden partner of conflict. After the fall of Baghdad in 2003, about 15,000 objects were stolen from the Iraq Museum. In Syria and Iraq, satellite imagery showed archaeological sites pockmarked by thousands of illegal excavation pits, and ISIS taxed and sold antiquities to finance its

operations. The UN Security Council responded with resolution 2199 (2015), banning trade in cultural property from Iraq and Syria.

In peacetime, looting feeds a global market in which provenance is often falsified. Social media and online marketplaces have made it easier to sell small, hard-to-trace objects. Weak border controls, corruption, and the low priority given to cultural crime by many police forces make the problem worse. In Sudan, authorities reported recovering 570 looted artefacts by January 2026 with help from INTERPOL and UNESCO, a fraction of what was taken.

3. Overtourism and Visitor Pressure

Tourism is both heritage's best friend and one of its greatest threats. It pays for conservation and gives local people a reason to protect sites. But uncontrolled crowds wear down floors and stairs, raise humidity in painted tombs and caves, create litter and pressure on water and sewage, and push residents out of historic centres through rising rents and short-term rentals.

- **Venice (Italy)**, home to fewer than 50,000 people in its historic centre, has struggled for years with crowds of day-trippers and cruise passengers. After UNESCO warnings, Italy banned large cruise ships from the Giudecca Canal in 2021, and in 2024 Venice became the first city to charge day-trippers an access fee. In 2026 the fee applied on 60 peak days and raised more than EUR 5 million; the city is now considering much higher fees.
- **Acropolis of Athens (Greece)** received up to 23,000 visitors a day in 2023. Greece introduced a cap of 20,000 visitors a day with hourly time slots, enforced since 2024.
- **Machu Picchu (Peru)**, **Angkor (Cambodia)**, **Dubrovnik (Croatia)** and **Barcelona (Spain)** have all introduced ticket caps, timed entry, limits on cruise passengers or restrictions on short-term rentals.

4. Urban Development, Infrastructure and Extractive Industries

Roads, dams, high-rise buildings, ports and mines can damage sites directly or destroy their setting. The World Heritage Committee has delisted Dresden Elbe Valley (2009) over the Waldschlösschen Bridge and Liverpool (2021) over waterfront development. The Historic Centre of Vienna spent nine years on the Danger List over a high-rise project before being removed in 2026. The United Kingdom's plan for a road tunnel near Stonehenge was a source of conflict with UNESCO for years before it was cancelled in 2024. Mining is a major threat in many regions: Roșia Montană (Romania), an ancient Roman gold-mining landscape, was inscribed directly on the Danger List in 2021.

The root problem is that development decisions are often made before any Heritage Impact Assessment is done, or without consulting the communities and experts concerned. Governments under economic pressure may also see heritage protection as an obstacle to growth.

5. Climate Change and Pollution

Climate change is anthropogenic and is now one of the fastest-growing threats to heritage. Rising seas and storm surges threaten coastal sites from Venice to the stone towns of East Africa and the

moai of Rapa Nui (Easter Island). Wildfires, more frequent and intense heatwaves, floods and changes in humidity damage buildings, wall paintings and archaeological remains. In 2023, extreme heat forced the temporary closure of the Acropolis. For natural and mixed sites, the IUCN's 2025 World Heritage Outlook found that climate change is a high threat in 43% of sites (117 of 271), up from 33% in 2020.

Local pollution adds to the damage. Acid rain and car exhaust erode marble and limestone; air pollution from nearby industry yellowed the Taj Mahal, prompting India's Supreme Court to create a protected Taj Trapezium Zone. Plastic and sewage pollute underwater and coastal heritage.

6. Neglect, Poor Management and Inappropriate Restoration

Not all damage is dramatic. Many sites deteriorate quietly because there is no money, no trained staff, no maintenance plan and no inventory. Fires at the National Museum of Brazil (2018) and Notre-Dame de Paris (2019) showed how quickly underfunded or poorly protected buildings can be lost. Badly planned restorations using the wrong materials, such as cement on ancient stone, can cause more harm than good. Regional inequality is stark: in 2026, 23 States Parties still had no property on the World Heritage List, and Africa is home to roughly one in ten listed properties but a large share of the Danger List.

Heritage, Equity and Communities

The burden of protecting heritage is not shared equally. Wealthy States can afford digital surveys, fire suppression, climate adaptation and specialised police. Many developing States cannot, even though they hold some of the world's most valuable and most threatened sites. Local and Indigenous communities are often excluded from decisions about sites they have cared for over centuries, or are displaced when sites are developed for tourism. Effective mitigation must therefore combine international solidarity with local ownership: communities who benefit from heritage are its best guardians.

Major Actors Involved

Hellenic Republic (Greece)

Greece, home to about 20 World Heritage properties following the inscription of the wider area of Mount Olympus in 2026, is one of the most active States on heritage diplomacy. It has tabled the General Assembly resolution on the *Return or restitution of cultural property to the countries of origin* for decades; the 2024 version (A/RES/79/133) was adopted by consensus with 146 co-sponsors. Greece campaigns for the return of the Parthenon Sculptures from the British Museum. At home, it introduced the 20,000-a-day visitor cap and timed entry at the Acropolis and faces growing climate threats from heatwaves and wildfires.

Italian Republic (Italy)

Italy has the largest number of World Heritage properties in the world (over 60) and pioneered specialised heritage policing through the Carabinieri Command for the Protection of Cultural

Heritage, founded in 1969. Italy co-drafted Security Council resolution 2347 (2017) and signed the 2016 agreement with UNESCO creating the first national "Blue Helmets for Culture" task force. It also faces some of the sharpest overtourism and climate pressures, most visibly in Venice.

French Republic (France)

France hosts UNESCO's headquarters in Paris and co-founded, with the United Arab Emirates, the International Alliance for the Protection of Heritage in Conflict Areas (ALIPH) in 2017. It co-drafted resolution 2347 and is a leading voice on prosecuting heritage crimes. France's own heritage experience includes the 2019 Notre-Dame fire and the cathedral's reopening in December 2024.

Ukraine

Ukraine is the site of the largest documented damage to cultural heritage in Europe since the Second World War. It works closely with UNESCO, ICOMOS and ALIPH on damage assessment, emergency protection and digital documentation, and seeks accountability for attacks on its heritage. In 2023 the historic centres of Odesa, Kyiv's St Sophia and the Kyiv-Pechersk Lavra, and Lviv were placed on the Danger List; the Ancient City of Tauric Chersonese was added in 2026.

Russian Federation

Russia is a party to the 1954 Hague Convention and its First Protocol but not the Second Protocol. It rejects accusations that its forces target heritage and has criticised what it sees as the politicisation of UNESCO. It also points to its own restoration programmes, including in Syria. Its position will likely emphasise State sovereignty and oppose mechanisms it sees as one-sided.

State of Israel and State of Palestine

Heritage in Gaza, the West Bank and Jerusalem is among the most contested on the UNESCO agenda. The State of Palestine (a full UNESCO member since 2011) documents extensive damage in Gaza and has several properties on the Danger List, including Hebron/Al-Khalil Old Town, Saint Hilarion Monastery in Gaza and Sebastia, inscribed in 2026. Israel, which left UNESCO at the end of 2018, rejects claims of deliberate targeting, argues that armed groups use civilian and cultural sites for military purposes, and views many UNESCO decisions as biased. Delegates should handle this topic with care and accuracy.

Lebanese Republic (Lebanon)

Lebanon ratified the Second Protocol to the Hague Convention in 2023 and has since secured enhanced protection for 73 cultural properties. Despite this, strikes in the vicinity of Tyre and Baalbek continued, and Tyre and the Mount Amel castles were placed on the Danger List in 2026. Lebanon is a test case for whether enhanced protection can deter attacks.

Republic of the Sudan

Sudan's civil war has caused some of the worst museum looting of the 21st century. The government works with UNESCO and INTERPOL to trace stolen artefacts and has accused the Rapid Support

Forces and their backers of attempting to erase national identity. Sudan is a key example of how weak States struggle to protect heritage during internal conflict.

Republic of Iraq and Syrian Arab Republic

Both suffered massive deliberate destruction and looting under ISIS between 2014 and 2017. Iraq is now a model for post-conflict reconstruction through UNESCO's *Revive the Spirit of Mosul* initiative. Syria, after the fall of the Assad government in December 2024, faces the task of rebuilding sites such as Palmyra and Aleppo with limited resources and contested international engagement.

Republic of Mali

Mali's experience in Timbuktu led to the only ICC conviction focused solely on cultural destruction (Al Mahdi, 2016). The mausoleums were rebuilt by local masons with UNESCO support. Ongoing insecurity in the Sahel continues to threaten sites such as Djenné and the Tomb of Askia, both on the Danger List.

United States of America

The US announced in July 2025 that it will leave UNESCO on 31 December 2026, the third withdrawal in its history, citing what it described as UNESCO's divisive agenda and its admission of Palestine. It will remain a party to the 1972 World Heritage Convention and the 1954 Hague Convention, and it remains a major actor against antiquities trafficking through bilateral cultural property agreements and law enforcement. Its departure reduces UNESCO's budget by roughly 8%.

People's Republic of China

China has about 60 World Heritage properties and has become one of UNESCO's largest funders. It invests heavily in domestic conservation and digital documentation, such as at the Mogao Caves, and funds heritage projects abroad, including in Cambodia and Nepal. China generally favours State-led approaches that respect sovereignty and supports capacity-building for developing countries.

United Arab Emirates and Kingdom of Saudi Arabia

The UAE co-founded ALIPH and co-sponsored resolution 2347; it funds the reconstruction of the Al-Nouri Mosque and other sites in Mosul. Saudi Arabia has become a major heritage investor, including in AlUla and Hegra, and hosted the 45th World Heritage Committee in Riyadh in 2023. Both see heritage as part of national development and soft power, which can raise tensions between conservation and large-scale tourism projects.

Republic of Peru, Kingdom of Cambodia and Other Tourism-Dependent States

States whose economies rely on heritage tourism must balance revenue against preservation. Peru has repeatedly adjusted ticket caps at Machu Picchu, sometimes against protests from local businesses. These States are likely to support funding for sustainable tourism and oppose measures that would sharply cut visitor income.

United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO)

The UN's specialised agency for culture. It acts as secretariat to the heritage conventions, runs the World Heritage Centre, manages the Heritage Emergency Fund (created 2015), monitors damage in conflict zones, and trains customs, police and military personnel. Its Director-General since November 2025 is Khaled El-Enany of Egypt.

Advisory Bodies: ICOMOS, ICCROM and IUCN

The International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS) evaluates cultural sites for the World Heritage List and monitors their condition. The International Centre for the Study of the Preservation and Restoration of Cultural Property (ICCROM), based in Rome, trains heritage professionals, including in first aid for cultural heritage in crises. The International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) advises on natural sites and publishes the World Heritage Outlook.

International Alliance for the Protection of Heritage in Conflict Areas (ALIPH)

A Geneva-based foundation created in 2017 by France and the UAE with other donors. It funds emergency protection and rehabilitation of heritage in conflict and post-conflict zones, from Iraq and Mali to Ukraine.

The Blue Shield

The "cultural equivalent of the Red Cross", named after the emblem of the 1954 Hague Convention. Its national committees train armed forces and emergency services and prepare no-strike lists of heritage sites.

INTERPOL and the UN Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)

INTERPOL maintains the Stolen Works of Art database and the ID-Art app, which lets anyone check whether an object is reported stolen. UNODC addresses trafficking in cultural property as a form of transnational organised crime and supports national criminal justice responses.

International Criminal Court (ICC)

Under Article 8 of the Rome Statute, intentionally directing attacks against historic monuments and buildings dedicated to religion, education, art or science is a war crime. The Office of the Prosecutor adopted a Policy on Cultural Heritage in 2021.

UNITAR / UNOSAT

The UN satellite centre provides imagery and analysis used by UNESCO to assess damage to heritage in places where on-the-ground access is impossible, such as Gaza and parts of Ukraine.

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Event
1863	The Lieber Code requires Union forces in the American Civil War to protect libraries, museums and works of art.

1899 and 1907	The Hague Conventions prohibit the destruction and seizure of historic monuments in war.
1935	The Roerich Pact, signed in the Americas, protects cultural institutions in war and peace.
16 November 1945	UNESCO's Constitution is adopted in London.
14 May 1954	The Hague Convention for the Protection of Cultural Property in the Event of Armed Conflict and its First Protocol are adopted.
1960–1980	UNESCO's International Campaign to Save the Monuments of Nubia relocates Abu Simbel and Philae.
1966	UNESCO launches a campaign to save Venice and Florence after major floods.
14 November 1970	The UNESCO Convention on the Means of Prohibiting and Preventing the Illicit Import, Export and Transfer of Ownership of Cultural Property is adopted.
16 November 1972	The Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage is adopted.
1978	The first 12 sites are inscribed on the World Heritage List.
1991–1993	Dubrovnik is shelled and the Old Bridge of Mostar is destroyed in the wars in the former Yugoslavia.
24 June 1995	The UNIDROIT Convention on Stolen or Illegally Exported Cultural Objects is adopted.
17 July 1998	The Rome Statute lists attacks on historic monuments as a war crime.
26 March 1999	The Second Protocol to the Hague Convention creates enhanced protection and individual criminal responsibility.
March 2001	The Taliban destroy the Buddhas of Bamiyan, Afghanistan.
2 November 2001	The Convention on the Protection of the Underwater Cultural Heritage is adopted.

April 2003	The Iraq Museum in Baghdad is looted after the fall of the government.
17 October 2003	UNESCO adopts the Declaration concerning the Intentional Destruction of Cultural Heritage.
2007	The General Assembly of States Parties adopts the first Policy Document on the impacts of climate change on World Heritage.
2009	Dresden Elbe Valley is removed from the World Heritage List over a bridge construction.
2012	Armed groups destroy mausoleums in Timbuktu, Mali.
2015	ISIS destroys temples in Palmyra and sites in Nimrud and Hatra. Security Council resolution 2199 bans trade in cultural property from Iraq and Syria. UNESCO creates the Heritage Emergency Fund. General Assembly adopts resolution 69/281 on *Saving the cultural heritage of Iraq*.
2016	The Special Rapporteur in the field of cultural rights reports to the General Assembly on intentional destruction of cultural heritage (A/71/317). The ICC convicts Ahmad Al Faqi Al Mahdi for attacks on Timbuktu's heritage. The Human Rights Council adopts resolution 33/20 on cultural rights and the protection of cultural heritage.
March 2017	ALIPH is founded in Geneva. Security Council resolution 2347 is adopted unanimously, the first focused entirely on heritage protection.
2018	UNESCO launches *Revive the Spirit of Mosul*. A fire destroys most of the collection of the National Museum of Brazil.
April 2019	Fire severely damages Notre-Dame de Paris.
2021	Liverpool is removed from the World Heritage List. Italy bans large cruise ships from Venice's lagoon centre. The ICC

	Office of the Prosecutor adopts its Policy on Cultural Heritage.
February 2022	Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine begins; UNESCO starts verifying damage to cultural sites.
April 2023	War in Sudan begins; museums in Khartoum, Omdurman and Darfur are later looted.
September 2023	Greece's Acropolis visitor cap of 20,000 a day begins on a trial basis.
October 2023	The war in Gaza begins; UNESCO starts remote damage assessment using satellite data.
November 2023	The General Assembly of States Parties adopts the updated *Policy Document on Climate Action for World Heritage*.
April 2024	Venice introduces the world's first access fee for day-trippers to a historic city.
November 2024	UNESCO grants enhanced protection to 34 cultural properties in Lebanon.
6 December 2024	The General Assembly adopts A/RES/79/133 on return or restitution of cultural property, tabled by Greece.
July 2025	The United States announces it will leave UNESCO effective 31 December 2026.
October 2025	IUCN's World Heritage Outlook 4 finds climate change is the top threat to natural World Heritage.
March 2026	UNESCO verifies damage to 523 cultural sites in Ukraine and 164 in Gaza.
April 2026	UNESCO grants enhanced protection to 39 more Lebanese cultural properties.
19–29 July 2026	The 48th World Heritage Committee in Busan adds 25 sites to the List and six to the Danger List (total 58), including Tyre (Lebanon) and Tauric Chersonese (Ukraine).
31 December 2026	Scheduled date of US withdrawal from UNESCO.

UN Documents and International Agreements

Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948), Article 27, and International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (1966), Article 15

Date: 10 December 1948 (UDHR); 16 December 1966 (ICESCR)

Document: A/RES/217 (III); A/RES/2200 (XXI)

Both recognise the right of everyone to take part in cultural life. The Committee on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights' General Comment No. 21 (2009) explains that this includes access to cultural heritage. This is the legal basis for treating heritage protection as a human rights issue, which complements UNESCO's own heritage conventions.

Convention for the Protection of Cultural Property in the Event of Armed Conflict (The Hague, 1954) and its Protocols

Date: 14 May 1954 (Convention and First Protocol); 26 March 1999 (Second Protocol)

Document: UNESCO, Convention for the Protection of Cultural Property in the Event of Armed Conflict

The core treaty on heritage in war. Parties must safeguard cultural property on their own territory in peacetime and respect it during hostilities, including by not using it for military purposes. The First Protocol (1954) prevents the export of cultural property from occupied territory. The Second Protocol (1999) introduced *enhanced protection*, defined serious violations, and requires States to prosecute those responsible. The Hague Convention has around 135 States Parties, but fewer than 100 have joined the Second Protocol.

UNESCO Convention on the Means of Prohibiting and Preventing the Illicit Import, Export and Transfer of Ownership of Cultural Property (1970)

Date: 14 November 1970

Document: UNESCO, 1970 Convention

The main treaty against trafficking. Parties agree to control exports, prevent museums from acquiring illegally exported objects, and cooperate to return stolen property. It does not apply retroactively to objects removed before it entered into force for the States concerned. It is complemented by the **UNIDROIT Convention (1995)**, which provides private-law rules for the return of stolen objects.

Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage (1972)

Date: 16 November 1972

Document: UNESCO, World Heritage Convention

The most widely ratified UNESCO convention, with 196 States Parties. It created the World Heritage List, the List of World Heritage in Danger, the World Heritage Committee (21 elected States), and the

World Heritage Fund. Article 5 requires States to adopt policies to protect all heritage on their territory, not just listed sites. Article 6 obliges States not to take deliberate measures that could damage heritage in other States. The Convention's *Operational Guidelines* require management plans and Heritage Impact Assessments for projects affecting listed sites.

Convention on the Protection of the Underwater Cultural Heritage (2001) and Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage (2003)

Date: 2 November 2001; 17 October 2003

Document: UNESCO, 2001 and 2003 Conventions

The 2001 Convention protects shipwrecks and submerged sites from commercial salvage and looting. The 2003 Convention protects living traditions, which are often tied to the physical sites discussed in this topic.

UNESCO Declaration concerning the Intentional Destruction of Cultural Heritage (2003)

Date: 17 October 2003

Document: UNESCO General Conference, 32nd session

Adopted after the destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas. It is not binding, but it states that States should take all appropriate measures to prevent, avoid, stop and punish intentional destruction of heritage, in war and in peace, and that States responsible bear international responsibility.

Security Council Resolution 2199 (2015)

Date: 12 February 2015

Document: S/RES/2199 (2015)

Primarily about terrorist financing, it banned all trade in cultural property illegally removed from Iraq since 1990 and from Syria since 2011, recognising that ISIS profited from looted antiquities.

General Assembly Resolution 69/281: Saving the Cultural Heritage of Iraq (2015)

Date: 28 May 2015

Document: A/RES/69/281

Adopted by consensus, it condemned the destruction of Iraq's heritage by ISIS and called on States to prevent trafficking and support UNESCO's work.

Human Rights Council Resolution 33/20: Cultural Rights and the Protection of Cultural Heritage (2016)

Date: 30 September 2016

Document: A/HRC/RES/33/20

Recognised that destroying cultural heritage can harm the enjoyment of human rights and called on States to respect, protect and promote cultural rights, including by ensuring accountability and training military personnel. It built directly on the work of the Special Rapporteur in the field of cultural rights.

Report of the Special Rapporteur in the Field of Cultural Rights to the General Assembly (A/71/317, 2016)

Date: 9 August 2016

Document: A/71/317

Karima Bennoune's report set out a human rights approach to the intentional destruction of heritage in conflict and non-conflict situations. It described such destruction as a form of cultural warfare and *cultural cleansing*, called for protection of heritage defenders, and urged States to address damage caused by development and modernisation as well as war. It is a key reference for linking UNESCO's heritage work with human rights.

Security Council Resolution 2347 (2017)

Date: 24 March 2017

Document: S/RES/2347 (2017)

The first Security Council resolution entirely dedicated to heritage. Adopted unanimously on 24 March 2017 and drafted by France and Italy, it condemned unlawful destruction and trafficking by terrorist groups, affirmed that attacks on heritage may amount to war crimes, encouraged States to create national inventories and safe havens for endangered property, and welcomed the creation of ALIPH and UNESCO's Heritage Emergency Fund. It also recognised that UN peacekeeping mandates may include the protection of heritage, as the mandate of MINUSMA in Mali already did.

General Assembly Resolutions on Return or Restitution of Cultural Property to the Countries of Origin

Date: 6 December 2024 (latest)

Document: A/RES/79/133

A recurring General Assembly plenary item first adopted in 1973 and now regularly tabled by Greece. The latest, A/RES/79/133 (6 December 2024), was adopted without a vote. It urges States to fight trafficking, including online, to require proof of provenance for traded cultural goods, and to strengthen international cooperation for the return of cultural property, including property removed before the 1970 Convention.

UN Sustainable Development Goals (2015)

Date: 25 September 2015

Document: A/RES/70/1

Target 11.4 calls on States to "strengthen efforts to protect and safeguard the world's cultural and natural heritage". Target 16.4 addresses illicit financial flows and the recovery of stolen assets, and Target 8.9 promotes sustainable tourism that supports local culture.

Policy Document on Climate Action for World Heritage (2023)

Date: 22–23 November 2023

Document: WHC/23/24.GA/INF.8

Adopted by consensus by the General Assembly of States Parties to the World Heritage Convention in November 2023, updating the 2007 policy. It recommends that States integrate climate mitigation and adaptation into risk preparedness for all World Heritage properties and asks the World Heritage Centre to report on progress.

MONDIACULT 2022 and 2025

Date: 28–30 September 2022; 29 September – 1 October 2025

Document: MONDIACULT 2022 Declaration

The UNESCO World Conference on Cultural Policies and Sustainable Development. In Mexico City in 2022, ministers from about 150 States declared culture a "global public good" and called for culture to be a stand-alone goal in the post-2030 development agenda. A follow-up conference was held in Barcelona in 2025.

48th Session of the World Heritage Committee (Busan, 2026)

Date: 19–29 July 2026

Document: WHC/26/48.COM/16

The Committee inscribed 25 new sites, placed six sites on the Danger List (bringing it to 58), removed the Historic Centre of Vienna from it, and adopted a World Heritage Strategy for Small Island Developing States (2026–2034) backed by USD 13 million. The next session will take place in Istanbul, Türkiye, in 2027.

Previous Attempts to Solve the issue

The List of World Heritage in Danger and Reactive Monitoring

The Danger List has saved sites. Inscription often brings missions, funding and political attention, and dozens of sites have been removed after recovery, from the Bahla Fort in Oman to the Historic Centre of Vienna in 2026. However, some governments resist inscription because they see it as a stigma that harms tourism, and some sites have stayed on the List for decades. Delisting remains a rare and blunt tool: it removes the very framework that could protect a site. Overall, it has been effective as an alarm and a lever, but dependent on States' willingness to act and on limited funding.

Enhanced Protection under the Second Protocol

Lebanon's 73 properties under enhanced protection show the mechanism can be activated quickly in an emergency. Yet strikes continued near Tyre and Baalbek after protection was granted, and Tyre was placed on the Danger List in 2026. Many key States, especially those most often involved in armed conflict, have not joined the Second Protocol. While this attempt was legally strong, it turned out to be practically weak where belligerents ignore it or are not parties.

Criminal Accountability: the Al Mahdi Case

In 2016 the ICC sentenced Ahmad Al Faqi Al Mahdi to nine years in prison for directing attacks on nine mausoleums and a mosque door in Timbuktu. In 2017 the Court ordered EUR 2.7 million in reparations to the community of Timbuktu, implemented through the Trust Fund for Victims. It was a landmark: the first international conviction focused solely on destruction of cultural heritage. The International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia had earlier convicted commanders for the shelling of Dubrovnik. But prosecutions remain extremely rare, and many States lack national laws that criminalise heritage destruction in line with the Second Protocol.

Emergency Funding: ALIPH and the Heritage Emergency Fund

ALIPH has funded hundreds of projects across dozens of countries since 2017, from rebuilding museums in Mosul to emergency roofing of damaged buildings in Ukraine. UNESCO's Heritage Emergency Fund finances rapid response, first-aid training and damage assessment. Since 2022, UNESCO has mobilised more than USD 75 million for Ukraine's cultural, educational and media sectors. These funds are flexible and fast but rely on voluntary contributions from a small group of donors and cover a fraction of needs: UNESCO estimated Ukraine alone will need about USD 9 billion over a decade to rebuild its culture and tourism sectors.

Post-Conflict Reconstruction: Mosul and Timbuktu

UNESCO's *Revive the Spirit of Mosul*, funded mainly by the UAE and the European Union, rebuilt the Al-Nouri Mosque and its leaning Al-Hadba minaret, the Al-Tahera and Al-Saa'a churches, and historic houses, while training and employing local young people. In Timbuktu, local masons rebuilt the mausoleums using traditional techniques. Both projects are praised for involving local communities, though critics note the difficulty of balancing authenticity with rapid reconstruction.

Fighting Trafficking

Measures include resolution 2199's trade ban, INTERPOL's Stolen Works of Art database and ID-Art app, specialised police units such as Italy's Carabinieri, EU import licensing for cultural goods (Regulation 2019/880), the ICOM Red Lists of objects at risk, and bilateral agreements such as those between the United States and dozens of source countries. These have led to major seizures and returns. Yet trafficking adapts quickly, especially online, and many countries lack the specialists or political will to prioritise cultural crime.

Managing Tourism: Caps, Fees and Timed Entry

The Acropolis cap of 20,000 visitors a day, Venice's access fee and limits on large cruise ships, timed tickets at Machu Picchu and visitor quotas at Maya Bay in Thailand are all recent attempts to manage overtourism. Early data from Venice suggest less crowding on peak days, but critics argue that fees of EUR 5–10 barely deter visitors, that caps are set too high, and that such measures can turn heritage into an exclusive product for wealthy tourists. Revenues are also not always reinvested in the sites themselves.

Possible Solutions

Strengthening Heritage Protection Through National Legislation

One of the most effective ways to protect cultural heritage is through the adoption and enforcement of national legislation that safeguards cultural sites and objects from destruction, exploitation and illicit trafficking. Although international agreements, such as the 1954 Hague Convention and the 1970 UNESCO Convention, provide a legal framework for heritage protection, their effectiveness largely depends on how Member States implement their provisions domestically.

National governments could strengthen their existing legislation by introducing stricter penalties for intentional destruction and illicit trafficking of cultural property, while also improving cooperation between law enforcement agencies, customs authorities and cultural institutions. UNESCO and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) could assist countries with limited administrative and financial resources by providing technical expertise, legal guidance and training. Such cooperation would allow Member States to develop more effective mechanisms for protecting cultural heritage while maintaining responsibility for enforcement within their own territories.

Sustainable Tourism Management

Tourism is an important contributor to economic development, particularly for countries whose economies rely heavily on cultural and historical attractions. However, excessive visitor numbers can place significant pressure on heritage sites, resulting in physical deterioration, environmental damage and the disruption of local communities. Establishing sustainable tourism management systems could therefore allow countries to benefit economically from their cultural heritage without compromising its long-term preservation.

One possible approach would involve determining the maximum number of visitors that a heritage site can accommodate without suffering significant damage. Based on these assessments, local authorities could introduce visitor limits, timed-entry systems and seasonal restrictions, while encouraging tourism in lesser-known destinations to reduce pressure on heavily visited sites. Furthermore, a percentage of the revenue generated through entrance fees and tourism-related taxes could be allocated directly to conservation projects and local communities. Such measures would help ensure that the economic benefits of tourism contribute to the preservation of the cultural resources upon which the industry depends. Nevertheless, visitor restrictions and pricing policies

would need to account for accessibility, ensuring that local residents and economically disadvantaged individuals are not excluded from their own cultural heritage.

Integrating Cultural Heritage Protection into Economic Development

Economic development projects, including the construction of transportation networks, residential areas and commercial infrastructure, can threaten cultural heritage when their potential consequences are not adequately assessed. Introducing Heritage Impact Assessments before the approval of major development projects could provide a means of identifying and mitigating such risks while allowing necessary economic investments to proceed.

These assessments would examine how proposed projects might affect historical monuments, archaeological sites, traditional settlements and their surrounding environments. Independent specialists, local authorities and affected communities could participate in the evaluation process, ensuring that both economic interests and cultural considerations are represented. Depending on the findings, governments could require modifications to construction plans, establish protective buffer zones or introduce additional conservation measures before granting approval.

International financial institutions and private investors could also incorporate heritage protection requirements into their financing agreements, encouraging developers to consider cultural preservation from the earliest stages of planning. Through these mechanisms, Member States could pursue economic growth without treating the destruction or deterioration of cultural heritage as an unavoidable consequence of

Further reading

UNESCO World Heritage Centre – the official site for the World Heritage List, the List of World Heritage in Danger and state of conservation reports.

IUCN World Heritage Outlook – assessments of threats to natural World Heritage, including climate change.

Policy Document on Climate Action for World Heritage (2023)

Security Council Resolution 2347 (2017)

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